Company Policies

Code of Conduct, Workplace Standards and Operating Rules for Employees of Data Axle India

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Policy Owner: Head of People Operations, India (Priya Deshmukh)
Approved By: Managing Director, India (Rohan Kulkarni)
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Applies To: All employees, contractors, interns and consultants working for Data Axle India at any location
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1. Purpose and Scope

Data Axle India Private Limited ("Data Axle" or "the Company") is the India delivery centre of the Data Axle group, providing data engineering, data quality, analytics and marketing technology services to group companies and their clients. The Company operates from its registered office at Axle House, Plot 12, Rajiv Gandhi Infotech Park Phase 2, Hinjawadi, Pune, Maharashtra 411057, and from a satellite office in Bengaluru.

This document sets out the core standards of behaviour and the operating rules that every person working for Data Axle India is expected to follow. It should be read together with the HR Policies (DA-IN-HR-002), the Leave Policy (DA-IN-HR-003) and the annual Holiday Calendar (DA-IN-HR-004). Where a local law provides a higher standard than this document, the law prevails. Where this document is silent, employees are expected to act in the spirit of the Company's values: Be Accurate, Be Accountable, Be Respectful and Be Curious.

2. Code of Conduct

2.1 Professional Behaviour

Employees must act with honesty and integrity in all dealings with colleagues, clients, vendors and the public. Every employee is required to complete the annual Code of Conduct acknowledgement in the Axle Connect people portal within 30 days of joining and thereafter by 31 January each year. Managers are responsible for ensuring that the members of their team have completed the acknowledgement.

2.2 Equal Opportunity and Anti-Discrimination

Data Axle is an equal opportunity employer. Decisions on hiring, compensation, promotion, training and separation are made on the basis of merit and business need. Discrimination or harassment on the basis of gender, religion, caste, race, region, language, age, disability, marital status, sexual orientation or any other characteristic protected by law is prohibited and will be treated as gross misconduct.

2.3 Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH)

The Company maintains an Internal Committee (IC) constituted under the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013. The IC is chaired by the Presiding Officer, Anjali Menon (Director, Client Delivery), and includes an external member from a registered NGO. A complaint may be submitted in writing to posh.india@data-axle.in within three months of the incident. The IC completes its inquiry within 90 days of receiving a complaint, and the Company acts on the recommendation within 60 days of receiving the report. Retaliation against a complainant or a witness is itself a disciplinary offence.

2.4 Conflict of Interest

Employees must avoid situations where personal interests conflict, or appear to conflict, with the interests of the Company. Any outside employment, directorship, consulting engagement or financial interest of more than 2 percent in a client, competitor or vendor must be disclosed in writing to the employee's HR Business Partner (HRBP) before it is taken up. Employees may not participate in hiring or vendor selection decisions involving a relative.

2.5 Gifts, Hospitality and Anti-Bribery

Employees may accept unsolicited gifts or hospitality from a business partner only if the value does not exceed INR 5,000 per instance and INR 15,000 in a calendar year from the same source. Cash, gift cards and gifts offered during an active tender or negotiation are never acceptable. Anything above the limit must be declined or, where declining would cause offence, surrendered to the Administration team and recorded in the gift register. Offering or accepting any payment or benefit to influence a business decision, including facilitation payments to public officials, is strictly prohibited.

3. Confidentiality and Data Protection

Data Axle processes large volumes of business and consumer data on behalf of group companies and clients. Every employee signs a Confidentiality and Intellectual Property Agreement at joining, and the obligations under that agreement continue after employment ends. All information handled by the Company is classified into one of four levels, and handling rules follow the classification:

- **Public:** information approved for external release by Corporate Communications.
- **Internal:** day-to-day operational information intended for employees only, such as this policy document.
- **Confidential:** client deliverables, financial data, employee personal data and unreleased product plans. Confidential information may be shared only on a need-to-know basis and never through personal email or messaging apps.
- **Restricted:** consumer datasets, credentials, encryption keys and source data received under client contract. Restricted data may be accessed only from Company-managed devices inside approved environments and must never be copied to removable media, personal cloud storage or generative AI tools that have not been approved by Information Security.

Suspected loss or unauthorised disclosure of Confidential or Restricted data must be reported to security.india@data-axle.in within one hour of discovery. The Information Security Officer, Sameer Joshi, coordinates the incident response and any regulatory or client notifications.

4. Acceptable Use of Technology and Information Security

- Company laptops, accounts and networks are provided for business use. Limited personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with work, consume significant bandwidth or breach any Company policy.
- Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all Company systems. Passwords must be at least 14 characters, must not be reused across systems and must never be shared, including with IT staff.
- Laptops must remain encrypted with the Company's standard disk encryption and must be locked whenever unattended. Employees must install security updates within 5 working days of release.
- Only software listed in the approved software catalogue may be installed. Requests for other tools are raised through the IT Service Desk and reviewed by Information Security within 5 working days.
- Client data may not be uploaded to public generative AI services. The Company provides an approved enterprise AI workspace for such use; only data classified Internal or below may be used with unapproved external AI tools.
- A clean desk standard applies in all offices: printed Confidential or Restricted material must be locked away or shredded at the end of the day.
- Lost or stolen devices must be reported to the IT Service Desk and to security.india@data-axle.in immediately so that the device can be remotely wiped.

5. Working Hours, Hybrid Work and Work From Home

5.1 Standard Working Hours

The standard working week is Monday to Friday. The standard working day is 9 hours inclusive of a 60-minute meal break, normally from 9:30 AM to 6:30 PM Indian Standard Time. Employees may start between 8:30 AM and 10:30 AM provided they are available during the core collaboration hours of 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM and complete the standard working day. Teams supporting North American clients may operate an approved shift schedule; shift allowances for such teams are described in the HR Policies.

5.2 Hybrid Working Model

Data Axle India follows a hybrid model. Every employee is expected to work from their assigned office for a minimum of 3 days in each week. Tuesday and Wednesday are Company-wide anchor days on which all employees attend the office; the third day is agreed within each team. The remaining 2 days may be worked from home. Attendance on anchor days is recorded through the office access system and is reviewed monthly by HRBPs.

5.3 Work From Home Conditions

- Employees working from home must be reachable on collaboration tools during core hours and must attend scheduled meetings with camera on unless connectivity prevents it.
- Work must be performed only from within India unless prior written approval for international remote work has been obtained from the HRBP and Information Security. Such approval is limited to 20 calendar days in a year.
- A stable broadband connection is required. Eligible employees receive the internet reimbursement described in the HR Policies.
- Fully remote arrangements, meaning fewer than 3 office days a week on an ongoing basis, require written approval of the Managing Director, India and are reviewed every 6 months.
- Working from home on an anchor day requires prior approval from the reporting manager and is expected to be exceptional. More than 2 such exceptions in a month are escalated to the HRBP.

6. Attendance and Punctuality

Attendance is recorded in Axle Connect through the office access system or, on work-from-home days, through the web check-in. An employee who arrives after 10:30 AM without prior intimation on more than 3 occasions in a calendar month is marked for a punctuality review with the reporting manager. A day on which fewer than 4.5 hours are logged is treated as a half day, and a day with no attendance record and no approved leave is treated as unauthorised absence and adjusted against leave balance or salary in accordance with the Leave Policy. Unauthorised absence of 5 or more consecutive working days is treated as abandonment of employment and is handled under the disciplinary process.

7. Business Travel and Expenses

All business travel must be approved in Axle Connect before booking, and bookings must be made through the Company's travel desk. Air travel is in economy class for all employees irrespective of grade; rail travel is in AC 2-tier or Chair Car. Expenses are reimbursed against original bills submitted within 30 days of the travel end date. The following limits apply to domestic travel in India:

- Hotel accommodation: up to INR 6,000 per night in Mumbai, Delhi NCR, Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, Kolkata and Pune; up to INR 4,000 per night in all other cities. Taxes are reimbursed over and above the limit.
- Daily allowance for meals and incidentals: INR 2,500 per day in the metro cities listed above and INR 1,800 per day elsewhere. No bills are required for the daily allowance.
- Local conveyance: app-based cabs or metered taxis at actuals. Use of a personal vehicle is reimbursed at INR 12 per kilometre for four-wheelers and INR 5 per kilometre for two-wheelers.
- International travel limits are set per country by Finance and communicated with the travel approval.

Expense claims are approved by the reporting manager and audited by Finance. Claims above INR 25,000 require the additional approval of the department head. Alcohol, personal entertainment, fines and expenses for accompanying family members are not reimbursable.

8. Workplace Health and Safety

The Company provides a safe working environment and expects employees to follow the safety instructions issued by the Administration team. Emergency exits, assembly points and fire wardens are displayed on every floor. Smoking is permitted only in the designated area outside the building. Employees must report accidents, near misses and unsafe conditions to admin.india@data-axle.in on the same day. Possession or consumption of alcohol or illegal substances on Company premises, or reporting to work under their influence, is prohibited.

9. External Communication and Social Media

Only authorised spokespersons may speak to the media or make public statements on behalf of Data Axle. Employees may identify themselves as Data Axle employees on professional networks but must make it clear that personal views are their own, must not disclose Confidential or Restricted information, and must not comment on clients, competitors or unreleased work. Requests from journalists, analysts or regulators should be directed to communications@data-axle.in.

10. Speak Up and Whistleblower Protection

Employees who become aware of a suspected violation of law or Company policy are expected to raise it. Concerns may be raised with the reporting manager, the HRBP, or confidentially through the Speak Up channel at speakup@data-axle.in or the toll-free helpline 1800-209-4410, which is operated by an independent third party and is available in English, Hindi and Marathi. Reports may be made anonymously. The Company does not tolerate retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith, and every report is acknowledged within 3 working days and investigated by the Ethics Committee.

11. Disciplinary Process

Breaches of this document are addressed through a fair and proportionate process. Depending on the severity, outcomes may include verbal counselling, a written warning, a final written warning, withholding of increment or bonus, demotion or termination of employment. Before any written warning or higher sanction is issued, the employee is informed of the allegation in writing and given an opportunity to respond, normally within 5 working days. Gross misconduct, which includes fraud, theft, harassment, breach of Restricted data handling rules, violence and wilful insubordination, may result in termination without notice. An employee may appeal a disciplinary outcome in writing to the Head of People Operations within 10 working days of the decision.

12. Policy Governance

This document is owned by the People Operations function and approved by the Managing Director, India. It is reviewed every year in the fourth quarter so that the revised version can take effect on 1 January. Interim changes required by law are issued as addenda and communicated by email and on Axle Connect. Questions about the interpretation of any clause should be sent to people.india@data-axle.in.